
Model Policy Section, Internet Safety and Digital Citizenship Instruction

The Hackles Kit

A free kit by Competence Collective · competencecollective.org · quillsup.org · October 2026

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A generic section that a school board, district, school, college program, library or youth organization can adapt. It is a drafting aid written by a non-lawyer. Have counsel fit it to your state statute, your existing policy numbering and your insurance and mandatory-reporting rules. Bracketed items are for you to fill.
[COUNSEL TO CONFIRM]

The kit's State Atlas (23_State_Atlas, two parts) lists, for each state, what its author found about mandates for online-safety and abuse-prevention instruction, with a confidence rating and a list of unknowns. It is a research pointer, not a legal opinion. Read the statute itself. [VERIFY]

Policy [number]: Internet Safety and Digital Citizenship Instruction

[NUMBER].1 PURPOSE

The [Board / Library Board / Organization] believes that young people are safer online when they have clear skills, know that telling a trusted adult is always safe, and know whom to tell. This policy sets how [District / School / Library / Organization] provides instruction on safe, respectful and responsible use of the internet and digital technologies, and how it keeps families informed.

[NUMBER].2 LEGAL BASIS

This policy is intended to support, and does not replace, the following requirements. [Counsel: list and verify each.]

- Federal internet safety policy and education requirements for entities receiving E-rate discounts (Children's Internet Protection Act, 47 U.S.C. 254(h); 47 CFR 54.520). [VERIFY]
- [State statute on internet safety, social media, digital citizenship or media literacy instruction: citation, grades, and what it requires. See State Atlas entry for [state]. VERIFY]
- [State statute on child abuse prevention, dating violence or human trafficking instruction, if applicable. VERIFY]
- [State statute and board policy on parent notice, access to instructional materials and opt-out. VERIFY]
- Federal and state rules on student surveys and student privacy (including the Protection of Pupil Rights Amendment, 20 U.S.C. 1232h, and FERPA). [VERIFY; COUNSEL TO CONFIRM how they apply]

[NUMBER].3 INSTRUCTION

1. Each year, students in [grades] will receive instruction on: protecting accounts and personal information; recognizing scams, fake content and manipulation; respectful online behavior; recognizing unsafe contact and pressure; how and where to report; and when and how to get help.
2. Instruction will be age-appropriate, skills-based, non-graphic and free of shame. It will teach that a child who is tricked or pressured is never at fault.
3. The [Superintendent / Director] will identify the instructional resources used, which may include Hackles, a free kit published by Competence Collective, as a supplemental resource. Resource selection follows [instructional-materials policy number]. Use of a resource does not imply that it is endorsed or approved by the state. [VERIFY]
4. Instruction will not require students to create accounts, provide personal information, or use social media. [Exception: where a teacher

expressly directs educational use of a platform, if state law or policy allows. VERIFY]

5. [Grades 6 to 12 only, if applicable: Instruction will address the topics required by [statute], and where the primary resource does not cover a required component the [Superintendent] will assign other materials.]

[NUMBER].4 SENSITIVE CONTENT

1. Lessons on grooming, sextortion, fake or synthetic images, body safety, trafficking, or mental health and compulsive use are "sensitive lessons."
2. Before a sensitive lesson, the school will: (a) consult the school counselor, (b) give families written notice at least [14] days ahead with a description of the lesson and an offer to preview materials, (c) arrange an alternate activity for students whose families opt out, and (d) have the counselor or an administrator available during the lesson. [Adjust to state and district rules on notice and opt-out. COUNSEL TO CONFIRM]
3. Students will not be asked to disclose personal experiences, show private content, or describe sexual details.
4. A student who does not take part will not be penalized academically or socially, and the school will make sure the student knows whom to tell if something worries them.

[NUMBER].5 PARENT AND CAREGIVER RIGHTS

1. Families may review instructional materials on request [and online at ____].
2. Families may request an alternate activity for a sensitive lesson [as set out in [number].4 and state law].
3. The school will provide notices in the family's home language where possible. Translations of safety content will be checked by a qualified translator. [Local fill]
4. [State-specific: if law requires a website notice about instructional materials, the District will post it at _____. For Florida, see the kit's 20_Florida/District_Adoption_Guide.md. VERIFY]

[NUMBER].6 DISCLOSURE, REPORTING AND RESPONSE

1. All staff and volunteers who work with students will be trained, before delivering instruction, on how to respond to a disclosure.
2. Staff who suspect abuse, neglect, exploitation, trafficking or threats of harm will report as the law and this policy require, personally and promptly, and then notify the [administrator] and [counselor]. Notifying a supervisor does not replace a legal duty to report where the

law places that duty on the individual. [Local fill: reporting line, number and deadline. COUNSEL TO CONFIRM]

3. Staff will not view, copy, forward, screenshot or print suspected sexual images of a minor, including AI-generated or altered images. Staff will secure involved devices as directed by the [administrator or designee] and law enforcement. [Counsel to review device-handling and school-resource-officer language]
4. For a student at risk of self-harm, staff will stay with the student and follow [suicide-risk protocol number].
5. Staff will record disclosures on the confidential form and store it as the policy on student records directs.
6. The school will not discipline a student for telling.

[NUMBER].7 PRIVACY AND DATA

1. Instruction under this policy will use paper, projected slides and offline web pages. No student personal information will be sent to a vendor.
2. Evaluation will use class-level counts and tallies with no names or student IDs. Any survey of students is subject to [policy and federal rule] and requires [notice / written consent] where the law so requires. [COUNSEL TO CONFIRM]
3. Any new online tool used with students must complete [district technology and privacy review].

[NUMBER].8 STAFF TRAINING

[Staff] will receive at least [one 60 to 90 minute] session each year covering the lessons, the sensitive-lesson procedure, the disclosure response and local reporting routes. [If state law requires specific training, such as human trafficking awareness for staff, list it here. VERIFY]

[NUMBER].9 RECORDS AND EVALUATION

The [Superintendent / Director] will keep, by class or group, the number of lessons delivered and the dates of family notices, and will report to the [Board] at least annually. Reports will describe limits of the data and will not claim that instruction prevented harm.

[NUMBER].10 REVIEW

This policy and the resources it names will be reviewed every year in [August], including contact numbers, links, reporting routes and any change in law.

Drafting notes for counsel

QUESTION	WHY IT MATTERS
Is the kit "instructional materials" under your state's adoption or review rules?	Decides whether a formal review process, public inspection period or board hearing applies
Does your state or district require notice, opt-out or consent for these topics?	Rules differ widely; the kit's templates assume the more cautious approach
Do the optional paper surveys fall under PPRA's written-consent rule for protected areas?	The kit's own checklist flags a 2026-08-26 Department of Education letter on this. [VERIFY; COUNSEL TO CONFIRM]
Who in your system is the mandated reporter, and what is the deadline?	The kit gives blanks, not answers
How should staff and school resource officers handle a device with suspected images?	Criminal-law exposure; counsel and a law-enforcement liaison should decide
Is a library or youth organization covered by the same reporting statutes?	Varies by state and organization type
Does your insurer cover this program and any volunteers?	Hackles Day volunteers are not the publisher's agents

Pointers

- State Atlas: kit/23_State_Atlas/States_A-M.md and States_N-W.md, with Sources and Unknowns files.
- Florida: kit/20_Florida/District_Adoption_Guide.md, Florida_Statutes_and_Sources.md and the HB 379 Crosswalk.
- Counselor and sensitive-lesson process: kit/05_Teacher_Support/Counselor_Heads_Up_and_Opt_Out_Toolkit.md.
- Disclosure response: kit/05_Teacher_Support/Disclosure_and_Incident_Guide.md.